WEIGHTED GRADES · STUDENT DRAFT FOR THE WORK GROUP

Weighted Grades: What Families Need to Know

A short explainer drafted by a student member of the SPASD weighted grades work group, October 2026. This is a recommendation. The School Board makes the final decision.

What's changing

Right now, SPASD uses an unweighted 4.0 GPA, so an A counts the same in every class. The work group is recommending a **5.0 scale for the most challenging classes**. In a weighted class, an A would count as 5.0 instead of 4.0.

Which classes would be weighted

Weighted (5.0 scale)	Not weighted
AP courses	College-credit or certification classes that match a class the high school already offers
Capstone classes, including try-out music courses	Classes that don't transfer for credit to UW colleges and universities
Classes that earn college credit or an industry certification	

Counselors are reviewing the Madison College class list now. Every weighted class will be marked in the course guide so students know before they choose.

Who it applies to

The recommendation is to start with **students entering 9th grade in fall 2027** (the Class of 2031) and add a grade each year after that.

Why not current students? Current high schoolers chose their classes under the old rules. Changing the rules partway through would reward some choices after the fact and not others, and it would change class rank for students who are already being ranked. Starting with a new class means every student in it knows the rules before choosing a single course.

Open question for the work group: 69% of caregivers of current high schoolers asked for it to apply now. One option to consider is weighting classes taken from 2027–28 onward for every student, without recalculating past grades.

Questions families asked

Does it apply to my student? Under the recommendation, only to students starting 9th grade in fall 2027 or later.

Will past grades be recalculated? No. Grades already earned stay as they are.

How does it connect to Act 95 and college? Act 95 guarantees admission to Universities of Wisconsin schools for students in the top 10% of their class (top 5% for UW–Madison), so class rank matters. Many colleges also recalculate GPAs their own way. *[District to confirm how weighted GPA will be used for class rank and shown on transcripts.]*

Is it fair to students who can't take AP? Weighted classes have to be open to every student who meets the prerequisites. *[District to add how students get support to access these classes.]*

How can I give input? The plan goes to the Board's Teaching & Learning Committee on **November 2** (4:45 PM, District Service Center) and the full Board on **November 9**. Both meetings are open to the public.

Based on the work group's October 15 and 20 recommendations and the caregiver survey (531 responses, October 16–22, 2026). Items in brackets need district confirmation before this is shared with families. Spanish version to follow.

BOARD MEETINGS · NOVEMBER 2 AND 9, 2026

Weighted Grades Board Kit

A 2-minute public comment, a statement someone else can read for you, and talking points for the committee preview.

Before you go

- **Nov 2, 4:45 PM:** Teaching & Learning Committee preview, District Service Center. Small table, two Board members. Best chance for a real conversation.
- **Nov 9:** full Board of Education. Check the posted agenda for how to sign up for public comment, usually before the meeting starts. Comments are often limited to 2–3 minutes.
- Bring printed copies of the one-page summary (page 2) for Board members.
- Your shifts: you work both days. Ask to swap Nov 2 first (text below).

Public comment script (about 2 minutes)

Good evening, President McFarland and members of the Board. My name is Zackary Mark. I'm a student in the district and a member of the weighted grades work group.

In January, 31 students came to this Board to talk about Act 95. Since then, students have worked alongside district staff to build the plan you're seeing tonight, and I want to share three numbers.

First, 78%. That's the share of students in last year's Act 95 survey who chose some kind of weighted GPA.

Second, 70%. That's how many of the 531 parents and caregivers who answered this month support weighted grades, and it's almost the same at West and East.

Third, 69%. That's how many caregivers of current high schoolers want this to apply to their students now. Our plan starts with next year's freshmen, for good reasons, but those families deserve a clear answer about why, and I'd ask the Board to make sure that answer is part of how this is shared.

This plan rewards students for challenging themselves, and it was built with students at the table. I hope you'll support it, and I hope this is how more decisions get made in our district. Thank you.

Statement to be read for you (if you can't attend)

Members of the Board, I'm sorry I can't be here tonight; I'm at work. I'm a student on the weighted grades work group. Students asked for a fairer way to recognize challenging classes, and this plan does that. Students supported a weighted option in last year's Act 95 survey (78%), and 70% of caregivers support it this month. I'd ask one thing: that the district clearly explain to current high school families why the plan starts with next year's freshmen, since 69% of them hoped it would apply now. Thank you for including students in this decision. — Zackary Mark

Talking points for the Nov 2 committee preview

- Lead with the reason: the recommendation is built on rigor, and rigor was also caregivers' top factor (75%).
- Name the timing split yourself before a Board member hears it from a parent.
- Ask how weighted GPA will be used for class rank under Act 95. Families asked this more than anything except timing.
- Ask what support exists so every student can access weighted classes. That's opponents' strongest point.
- Offer students' help with the written explanation, since 72% of caregivers asked for one.

Text to Mr. Degnan about Nov 2

Hi Mr. Degnan, I have a School Board committee meeting on Monday, Nov 2 at 4:45 for the weighted grades plan I've been working on with the district. Would it be possible to swap or cover my shift that day? I'm happy to pick up another shift that week to make it up. Thank you!

ONE-PAGE HANDOUT FOR BOARD MEMBERS

What Students and Families Said

SPASD weighted grades · student summary · November 2026

Survey	Responses	Key finding
Act 95 student survey (Dec 2025 – Jan 2026)	903 students	**78%** of students who picked a ranking option chose a weighted GPA. 55% barely knew about Act 95 beforehand.
Caregiver survey (Oct 16–22, 2026)	531 caregivers	**70%** support weighted grades. West 68%, East 73%.
Caregiver survey: timing	462 answered	Current high school families: **69%** apply now. Families with only younger kids: **74%** start next year.
Caregiver survey: classes	531 caregivers	**85%** want AP weighted. Top factor: rigor (75%).
Caregiver survey: communication	531 caregivers	**72%** want a detailed written explanation.

What families want answered: Does it apply to my student? How does it affect Act 95 and college admissions? Which classes count? Is it fair to students without access? Is the decision already made?

Students' ask: Approve the plan, and share it with a clear written explanation that answers current families directly.

Both surveys were self-selected. Full analysis: spasdstudentvoice.netlify.app/resources/caregiver-survey-key-findings.pdf

PROPOSAL · FOR DR. REED, DR. MORGAN AND MS. BEVENUE

District Student Advisory Council: Pilot Plan

A spring 2027 pilot that can answer the shared goal from October 20: by June 2027, students can name something that changed because they spoke up.

The idea in one sentence

A small group of students from every SPASD middle and high school meets with district leaders on a regular schedule, brings what students are saying, and hears back what happened to it.

How it would work

Piece	Pilot plan
Who	3–5 students from each middle and high school (about 25–30 total), across grades, and reflecting each school's racial, gender and program mix. This follows Dr. Reed's August suggestion.
How students join	Short application open to every student (in English and Spanish), plus one seat per school saved for a student recommended by a counselor or teacher, to reach students who don't usually apply.
Staff partner	One district leader who owns the council, plus a staff contact at each school. **This is the first thing needed.**
Meetings	Four in the pilot: January, February, April and May 2027. 60 minutes, during the school day or right after, virtual option for middle schoolers.
Agenda	Each meeting: one district topic leaders want student input on, one topic students bring, and updates on earlier input.
Closing the loop	Within 30 days of each meeting, the district shares a short "You said, we did" update: what changed, what's in progress, and what can't happen and why.
Families	A parent team alongside, as Dr. Reed suggested, meeting twice during the pilot.
Cost	Mostly staff time. Possibly snacks, printing and transportation for after-school meetings.

Timeline

When	Step
November 2026	Name a staff partner. Agree on the pilot plan.
December 2026	Applications open at every school. Wider student survey runs (see the survey plan).
January 2027	Members selected. First meeting: survey results and setting priorities.
February–May 2027	Three more meetings, each followed by a "You said, we did" update.
June 2027	Review the pilot with students, staff and the Board. Decide whether to make it permanent.

How we'll know it worked

- Every middle and high school was represented at every meeting.

- At least three "You said, we did" updates were published.
- Students on the council can name at least one change that came from their input.
- In a June survey, more students say they know where to bring an idea than in December.

> **The ask:** name a staff partner by the end of November so applications can open in December.

Builds on the Student Advisory Council proposal (spring 2026), the August 2026 meeting with Superintendent Dr. Antoine Reed, and the October 20, 2026 meeting with Dr. Michael Morgan and Marlita Bevenue. Drafted by Zackary Mark, SPASD Student Voice.

PLAN · NOVEMBER–DECEMBER 2026

Outreach & Growth Plan

Goal: get beyond the same small group. Reach every high school, every grade, and students who don't usually speak up, which is what Dr. Morgan asked for on October 20.

Where we are

39 Instagram posts and 29 followers, also on Threads; a website that installs as a phone app; a bilingual survey. The reach is still mostly one school and one friend group. Every step below is about widening that.

Channels, ranked by reach

#	Channel	Ask	Owner	By
1	District student newsletter (starts November)	Survey link and blurb in the first issue	Ms. Bevenue (email drafted)	Nov 6
2	SP30 at both high schools	Teachers show the survey QR code once	Zack (email drafted)	Nov 13
3	Student Council and Student Senate (West and East)	Repost the survey and the newsletter win	Zack (DMs below)	Nov 6
4	Flyers	Get approval, then post at both high schools, the library and Kicks Unlimited	Zack	Nov 13
5	East High students	Recruit 2–3 co-leads from East	Zack (DM below)	Nov 20
6	Spanish-speaking families	Share Spanish posts with ELL teachers and family liaisons	Zack	Nov 20
7	Middle schools	Ask middle school principals to share the survey with 8th graders	Zack, after the council pilot is approved	Dec

Messages to send

DM to Student Council and Student Senate

> Hey! I run @spasdstudentvoice. Last week the district confirmed students will start getting the district newsletter in November because we asked for it. We're trying to get the student survey to every grade so district leaders hear from more than a few of us. Would you be willing to repost it to your story? Link's in our bio. Thank you!

DM to students at East

> Hey, I'm Zack. I've been working with district leaders on student voice stuff, like weighted grades and getting students the district newsletter. Right now it's way too West-heavy and I want East to have an equal say. Would you be down to help lead it with me? It's mostly sharing what students at East care about and coming to a meeting or two. No experience needed.

Posting calendar

Week of	Instagram / Threads
Oct 26	"You said, we did": newsletters (English + Spanish slides). Reel version.
Nov 2	Caregiver survey carousel and Reel. Story reminder: Board committee on Nov 2.
Nov 9	Story reminder: Board meeting tonight. Recap post after.
Nov 16	District story with the interview (if published). Survey push.
Nov 23	Weighted grades final vote result. Thanksgiving post.
Nov 30	November monthly update (same text as the site).
Dec 7	Advisory council applications (if approved). Survey last call.

What to measure

- Survey responses by school and grade (goal: every high school and grade has at least 25)
- Followers (goal: 100 by winter break)
- Messages through the site's form
- New co-leads (goal: 3, including at least one from East)

Drafted by Zackary Mark, SPASD Student Voice, October 2026.

PLAN · FOR DR. MORGAN'S OCTOBER 20 FEEDBACK

Wider Student Survey: What Good Student Voice Looks Like

The first step toward the June 2027 goal: ask students across the district what student voice working well looks and sounds like, then set goals from their answers.

Who we need to hear from

Group	Target	How
Sun Prairie West, grades 9–12	25+ per grade	SP30, Student Senate, newsletter
Sun Prairie East, grades 9–12	25+ per grade	SP30, East co-leads, newsletter
Prairie Phoenix Academy and Sun Prairie Virtual	As many as possible	Staff contact at each
Middle schools (grade 8)	Pilot with one or two schools	Principal-approved, short version
Spanish-speaking students	Included in every group	Spanish version, ELL teachers

We'll ask optional questions on school, grade, and how students describe their identity, so we can check whether the people who answered match the district, and report gaps honestly.

Draft questions (5 minutes)

1. Which school and grade are you in?
2. Do you know where to bring an idea or concern at school? (Yes / Not sure / No)
3. In the last year, did you ever see something change because students asked for it? If yes, what?
4. When something serious happens at school, how do you usually find out? (District/school message, teacher, friends, social media, news, I don't)
5. Rate: "Adults in my school listen to students' ideas." (1–5)
6. What would student voice working well look or sound like at your school? (open)
7. Which matter most to you right now? (pick up to 3: safety, mental health, grades and class rank, schedules, lunch, communication, fairness in discipline, clubs and activities, other)
8. How would you want to hear back about student input? (newsletter, Instagram, in class, website, email)
9. Would you want to be part of a student advisory council? (Yes / Maybe / No)
0. Anything else district leaders should know? (open)

Timeline

When	Step
Nov 2026	Share draft questions with Dr. Morgan; translate; get approval to share through district channels.
Dec 1–18, 2026	Survey open. Weekly check on who's answered; push to groups that are behind.
Jan 2027	Results report (public, anonymous) and three to five goals with benchmarks, shared with the advisory council at its first meeting.
May 2027	Short follow-up survey to measure change for the June 2027 check-in.

Privacy

- Anonymous by default; no names or student IDs.
- Results shared only as summaries. Quotes only when they can't identify anyone.
- Any serious safety concern a student writes about is passed to district staff, and the survey says so up front.

Drafted by Zackary Mark, SPASD Student Voice, October 2026.

GUIDE · FOR ANY STUDENT

How to Start Student Voice at Your School

What worked in Sun Prairie this year, written so another student can copy it.

1. Start with one clear letter

Write to your principal or School Board about one thing students are worried about. Say what happened, how it affects students, and two or three specific, doable asks. Keep it respectful. You're asking to be part of the solution, not blaming anyone.

2. Ask for a meeting, then write it down

Ask for 30 minutes. Bring a one-page handout. Take notes, and ask before recording. Within two days, email a short recap ("so we all leave with the same notes"). That recap is what turns a nice conversation into a commitment.

3. Get real input, not just your friends'

Run a short anonymous survey in every language families speak. Share it through teachers and newsletters, not only social media. Report who answered, including who's missing.

4. Keep a public record

Post short updates: what you asked, what you were told, what changed. A free website and an Instagram account are enough. Give district leaders a chance to correct anything before you post it, and set a deadline.

5. Track promises

Keep a "You said, we did" list. Every commitment gets an owner, a date and a status. Celebrate wins publicly; it's the best proof that speaking up works.

6. Join the groups that already exist

Work groups, Student Senate and Board student sessions are where decisions get made. Ask to join them before starting something new.

7. Protect people

- Don't post names of students, private phone numbers, or rumors about staff.
- Stick to facts from public records and the news.
- If someone tells you they're unsafe, help them reach a trusted adult right away.

8. Make it last after you graduate

Recruit co-leads from different grades and schools early. Share passwords and files with them. Push for something permanent, like an advisory council, so student voice doesn't depend on one person.

Handoff plan for SPASD Student Voice (Class of 2027 graduation): recruit 3 co-leads by December 2026, including one from East and one underclassman; share the Instagram, website and records with them by March 2027; co-leads run the April and May updates; full handoff by June 2027.

Templates for the letter, recap email and survey are on spasdstudentvoice.netlify.app. Written by Zackary Mark.

TEMPLATE · FOR THE DISTRICT

"You Said, We Did": Semester Update

A suggested one-page format the district could publish twice a year (January and June), so every student can see what happened to their input.

Opening (2–3 sentences)

This semester, students shared ideas through [surveys, the student advisory council, Student Senate, meetings]. Here's what we heard and what happened.

What changed

You said	We did	When
Students never got the district newsletter.	Newsletters now go to students as well as families.	November 2026
Harder classes should count more toward GPA.	[Weighted grades decision, if approved]	[Date]
[Student input]	[Action]	[Date]

In progress

You said	What's happening	Next update
Students want to know when outside agencies get involved and when parents are told.	[Student rights guide in progress]	[Date]
[Student input]	[Status]	[Date]

What we can't do, and why

You said	Why not (law, budget, safety)	What we can do instead
[Student input]	[Plain reason, naming the law when one applies]	[Alternative]

How to share an idea

[Where students bring ideas: the advisory council rep at your school, the student survey, your principal, or a form.] Students should hear back within 30 days.

> Tips: keep it to one page, write it for a 9th grader, publish it in the student newsletter and on the district website, and translate it into Spanish.

Suggested by students in the October 20, 2026 meeting with Dr. Morgan and Ms. Bevenue. Drafted by Zackary Mark, SPASD Student Voice.